

V **①** ^[33] Perhaps **willfully**^①, it may be easier to think about such lengthy timescales than about the more immediate future. **②** The potential evolution of today's technology, and its social consequences, is **dazzlingly**^② complicated, and it's perhaps best left to science **fiction**^③ writers and **futurologists**^④ to explore the many possibilities we can **envisage**^⑤. **③** That's one reason why we have launched *Arc*, a new **publication**^⑥ dedicated to the near future.

· 词汇注释与难句分析 ·

- ① **willfully** ['wɪlfəli] *ad.* 任性固执地

- ② **dazzlingly** [¹'dæzliŋli] *ad.* 耀眼地

- ③ **fiction** ['fɪkʃən] *n.* 小说; 虚构

- ④
- futurologist**
- [ˈfju:tʃəˈrɒlədʒɪst]
- n.*
- 未来学家

- ⑤
- envisage**
- [in'vɪzɪdʒ]
- v.*
- 想像

- ⑥
- publication**
- [ˌpʌblɪ'keɪʃən]
- n.*
- 出版物

The potential evolution of today's technology, and its social consequences, is dazzlingly complicated, and it's perhaps best left to science fiction writers and futurologists to explore the many possibilities we can envisage.

功能注释:分句 1 中的 and its social consequences 作为插入成分,起到对主语 the potential evolution of... 附带说明的作用;分句 2 采取 it is best to do sth 的结构说明作者对“当前技术可能的进展及其引发的社会影响”的看法;最好是留待小说家和未来学家探寻,暗示其难以预测。其中,leave sth to sb 意为“把某物交由某人(负责)”之意,此处 sth 由不定式 to explore... 充当,内容较长,故将间接宾语 to sb (to science fiction writers and futurologists) 提至直接宾语 to explore... 之前,句子采取被动语态, it 作形式主语,不定式 to explore the many... 充当真正主语。

第五段先让步否定“以短期视角审视未来的可行性”。关键词为：① immediate future; ② dazzlingly complicated。

①句承上指出作者对“思考近期未来”的看法:比“思考长远未来”更难。such lengthy timescales 回指前文 thousands of years hence, 与 more immediate future 相对; it may be easier to... than... (it 为形式主语)明确作者对两种视角的取舍。willful 意为 continuing to do what you want, **even it seems unreasonable**“执意做某事, 尽管看似不明智”, Perhaps willfully 实际承接上段末“建造一台几千年之后仍可计时的机械时钟”, 响应人们心中疑惑:近期未来理应更好把握, 为何要舍近求远?